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Benny Powell — Part II

Trombonist Benny Powell was born in New Orleans on March 1, 1930. He was playing professionally in his teens and joined the Lionel Hampton Band in 1948. In 1951 he joined the Count Basie Orchestra and quickly began sharing the trombone solo chores with section mate Henry Coker. Benny stayed with the Basie band for twelve years, winning the Down Beat *Critic's Poll in 1956 and recording frequently with small groups during this period. In the 60s he led his own combos, played with the Merv Griffin Show band, helped administer the Jazzmobile and continued big band work with Thad Jones and Mel Lewis. He spent much of the 70s in Los Angeles, where he performed with Bill Berry and Bill Holman. Benny currently lives in New York and tours with a jazz ensemble led by Randy Weston.*

Part II was conducted in New York City by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, on January 16, 1999.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in Manhattan for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, and I've been looking forward to having a follow-up conversation with Benny Powell. So welcome.

BP: Thank you. I should say welcome to you — you're in my neighborhood.

MR: Yes I am. It's always a bit of a charge to come into New York for us.

BP: Oh I know what you mean. I lived in California. I was doing the Merv Griffin Show from California, and almost every month, my daughter was still here. So I had to come and get my New York fix. Oh man, and then most of the guys out there, because we had this kind of vitality in New York, man we went out from New York and in a few months we had taken over everything. While the other guys went to the beach, we were doing all the studio gigs, film gigs, all kinds of stuff.

MR: They say, "Hey, what happened?"

BP: They'd say, "Which one is the guy in the Merv Griffin band? Oh, the one in the suit." Everybody's got shorts on and we're walking around in suits and stuff.

MR: That's great because you know the musicians have their own uniform almost.

BP: Well I find, yes they do, first of all I think they're real model type guys. But then that's the guys who are the entrepreneurs or the leaders. Now there's another uniform for the sidemen, and that's what I was alluding to when I was out there. I was a sideman but I

was a rebel sideman so I used to wear my — but guys, there are some guys who really make a very good livelihood at doing sideman — you know, film, and they go from there maybe to a big hotel and play a reception, and you know when the week is over they've made a couple of thousand dollars in those blue suits.

MR: Yeah. Did you ever have aspirations to just do that?

BP: Oh no, no, no. Mine started out, I guess I'd call myself a legitimate maverick, because I've been going against the tide all my life. But my secret is I can go against the tide and not be abrasive. In fact it seems like I'm going against the tide, I guess that's more prevalent in the way I've dressed always. I've always liked clothes so I made sure I didn't — well if I got clothes I would wear them, so as soon as I could pull off a tuxedo or whatever and put on my little slick stuff, I was only too happy to. So I never got caught in that trap. And then too I saw that just being a sideman was limiting, and I liked to do a bunch of things. I was interested in theater, I don't know, just being creative.

MR: You told me you had about 40 projects on the burner and, we'll get to maybe the first five anyway, but—

BP: Well I guess the first one that's the most important to me is education. I consider myself a jazz activist, therefore I can be active from kindergarten to Congress. Because of my studying acting or performing, I can perform in front of Congress just as well as I can perform in front of a kindergarten class. So I do consider myself — now education is the most important. It's through the education that I had that allows me all this freedom to wear whatever I want to. And to my family, education is most important. I'll give you a good example. I wish I had brought the pictures. Christmas I spent time with the youngest musician in my family. Musicians. They are two sisters. They played at Constitution Hall and Kennedy Center already, and their ages are three and five. They're studying the Suzuki method. My family has all sort of beautiful educational things. In my sister's home in Washington, D.C., she has on the kitchen table a book of gratitudes. And when anything — anybody comes in the house — they say, "Wow, I'm grateful I got home, I had a—" she'll write it down. So actually, and it's beautiful and it's one of the most intelligent things I ever heard of. But education is important to my family. We come from New Orleans and I guess we were told in my era, a lot of things we couldn't do. And we knew then that education was the key to it. But I think for most people from the

south, they have a keener desire, or they can see the feasibility of being educated. Because I know when I used to travel in Texas and Kentucky and all of that, the southern people have another thing about education. In fact, most of the black colleges are in the south. But anyway, in my family, because of education, it's always been important to me. I know it's allowed me the life that I have now. But you can see how early it can start. And if it starts at that age, well there's no big deal about it. You just know if you want to learn something, you have to work at it.

MR: You've been able to take your practical experience as a player and channel it into an educational delivery to the public schools?

BP: For 35 years. I've done — or maybe 40 — I've done what's called a lecture-demonstration. I think Billy Taylor started this in the 60s, where we lecture and we demonstrate. And I've been doing that constantly, every year, because for me it's been like a commitment. Naturally education — I've done all these Broadway shows and Count Basie and all of that, and I realized that education is the key to it. Because when I first started playing trombone, I think maybe last time I told you when I was 12 years old I played drums when I was 9. When I was 12 years old I was sitting on a couch, I looked at the back of it, there was a trombone. As soon as I thought I wanted to play trombone, my mother found me a good teacher. I was 12. So I was able to become professional at 14 years the guy I studied with was Eddie Pearson. And I was a little egghead anyway. I found me and most of my friends, Vernell Fournier, we all grew up together. We had a kid's band. I think we were 13 and 14, and we were working jobs. But it's because we were never silly guys. You see studying music, or sports or whatever I guess, maybe music more so because it's a kind of thought thing, you don't have to run out there. Anyway, it makes you a little old man. Most of the guys I talk to, you know when we talked in retrospect, they were all little old men, just like my little nieces and stuff. The one that's three years old is a little old spirit. Oh man, and you should see how naturally, when she's playing the violin, and she's in — I think some of it is because the teachers, she's emulating a teacher. But man it sure looks like the real thing. She looks like Itzak Perlman to me.

MR: It's already a part of her.

BP: Yeah. And it's amazing to see at three years old. Man, I had the greatest time. I wish we had — well we'll talk off the record about my Christmas holidays what I slipped to them. And another thing, since they're taking lessons — oh well their mother, they work with flash cards. Every morning at 8:30, their mother is teaching them at home. So she makes it fun. Flash cards are those cards, you know what flash cards, but I'm speaking for the people that don't know, it's a card with a staff on it and a note, but not the name of the note. So with their mother, she plays if they get it in a minute it's theirs, if they don't it's hers. So she makes a game out of it man, and all of this stuff, oh man, it's just so slick. Well I covered a lot of bases when I was in Washington over the Christmas holidays, because first of all I got there, I left here at 7 o'clock in the morning. I got there in time to go to 5 o'clock mass, at which these same two young ladies performed. One was a sheep and the other one was an angel. The one who wants to be a singer was an angel singing on stage. Oh man it was so funny. I hope this is not too far away from the point, but the one who was a sheep couldn't understand — she says, "Uncle Benny, I'm kind of worried about my line." She said, "When I tell my line to people they laugh and I can't understand why." I said, "What's your line?" She said, "Baaaa." Oh man, and it was all I could do to keep a straight face because she was seriously into it. Anyway when I would take my horn out to practice, they just reach for their violin automatically. It's not like come play with Uncle Benny. They think we're all supposed to play "Twinkle, Twinkle Little Star" with that Suzuki method.

MR: [scats] My kids did it too.

BC: You know the deal.

MR: Pepperoni pizza, isn't it?

BC: Because at first, so I knew "Twinkle, Twinkle Little Star," we played through that already. So I said, "What else do you guys know? And one of them said, "Chuckle Chuckle Stops Up." And I said, "I don't know that," and I said, "play it for me." Oh man. And then there was another one, "Run Mamma, Daddy." Anyway I had a great time with them. I got there and then we had a great Christmas. I don't have time to really tell you how funny, but the next day I had a gig in Washington at a club called Schwinns, with a local rhythm section, oh just great guys. I'm terrible for names. Alan Johnson I know was on piano. A nice rhythm section they just had to put together that I had the date

on. The following day I got up and did a shoot just like this for my niece who was putting together this footage. And I got on the bus that evening and in about three or four days I covered all forms of media.

MR: Wow. You know you said something that just struck me so much when I called you last week I guess. You said, "Oh I'm just here practicing with my Jamey Aebserold."

BP: Yeah.

MR: And talk about education, you're never quitting, you're still—

BP: Man, I was in Germany with Wild Bill Davison, the old cornet player, and man he had his little audiotape that he — and by this time he was about 387 years old, I mean this guy was old, but he had this little walkman and he put his tape on, put his cup mute in and got ready for the gig. Well I think I've watched people who have survived — well some people don't, Jane Jarvis doesn't have to practice. That's amazing. Well I guess she does — she keeps loosened up, but it comes easier for some people than others. I told you in the beginning, I found out early in my life, if I want to do something I have to work at it. So it comes easy for some people. But I don't think it comes easy for too many people. It seems like everybody I know, you know Randy Weston is the greatest pianist in the world, but I know every so often he'll sneak up the Steinway — well not sneak up — well he doesn't really — I don't know whether he practices that much or not. I work with him now, and it's a real joy to work with him. Every time he sits down at the piano, even if it's just, well usually he does it when we play concerts, he gets antsy, but he never fools around. It sounds like a concerto every time he sits down. It's amazing.

MR: He seems like a very spiritual person, reading his liner notes and so forth.

BP: Oh he is. Exceptionally spiritual. He is the most scholarly person I know. And he's done his research in libraries in Morocco, Germany — these guys man, it's amazing to be with them. Randy, Talib Kibwe, Neil Clark and this time I think there was a bass player from France who played with us, James — well I'm going to shoot myself — but I think he has a name like Williams or something. At any rate, these guys are always on, when we have a day off, they're out somewhere doing research in the library or something.

MR: It reminds me of something I remember you saying, and I'm going to quote you now, from our first interview. You said, "Most successful musicians understand humankind. Whether you're talking to a president or a porter you should be able to communicate."

BP: Oh well he does fantastic stuff. We went to Jamaica last year to play a festival there. Randy is so smooth. Well he lives in Morocco, and he travels back and forth. He lives in Marakesh and Brooklyn. But in the meantime, Randy's been working with the United Nations. If you see some of his albums, he has albums concerning Africa long before Africa was free. He's been living in Africa, I don't know 30 years, as well as here. So his whole communication skills, they're just magnificent. For example we were coming back from Jamaica and I saw him, as always, he is always the smoothest guy at the airport, because no matter what language it is, he has such a nice demeanor, and I don't know what he's saying but it sounds like he's saying I'm a nice guy, give me a break, and you're a nice person. Because he always is complimenting people. But at any rate I saw him with this ticket lady, I saw him put maybe about two tons of percussion and stuff on his first class ticket. All that luggage you know, you usually have to pay extra freight for that. He was, I don't know, somehow he talked to this lady and all the while he's saying — Randy forgive me, I'm telling your secrets but it's all good — all the while he's saying to us isn't she pretty? I love the people down here. The lady's writing one ton, two tons. But traveling with those guys is such a joy because they're all on a scholarly level. And well they're like 360 degrees, but it's all not about the last lady you saw. I'd better take this gum out of my mouth.

MR: We can park it somewhere.

BP: No, for that reason it's a pleasure. Alex Blake is the regular bass player with her, and he's phenomenal also. Alex Blake has, I think he comes from the Dominican Republic. But when he plays he has a strumming technique as well. With our group it's pretty — this is Randy Weston's group — it's pretty — oh I've got a picture of us in Spain. Each one of us can hold the stage by ourselves for a little while, and Alex just does it tremendously. Well I mean hold a solo spot for a little while. I don't know, shall we? This is from a concert we did in Seville Spain last year. I think it's really nice how they do it. It's from a newspaper but look at the fleshtones in Randy's hand and so forth. And there's Randy and there's — oh I'm sorry, maybe we should put this on a stand or something. Okay, I want to talk about this lady too. Our last album concerned the African presence in the Shang Dynasty. This is a Chinese woman and she's playing a Chinese instrument called the pipa. She's on our last album, Khepera it's called. But Randy has such a beautiful

way, he's like Duke Ellington. He can meld anything because I think, well I don't know, he has just the most beautiful organizational sense. Sometimes when we play Moroccans, sometimes we play with Moroccan musicians, Moroccans will start to play first, and I'm wondering now that's a bit different, I know it would be a challenge if I had to play with that, now what is Randy going to play with that? And in two or three minutes it sounds like they've been working together for years. But it's the same thing with this woman, Min Xiao Fen, she's a master at this instrument called the pipa. And this last tour we did, well you heard all of this on this album if you played this album. Have you played this album at all?

MR: Yes, in fact I had a little piece here to ask you about. If I can find it.

BP: She was a thorough trooper, traveling with us. She's not really, I don't guess she's used to doing one-nighters and stuff, but oh man.

MR: I wanted to find a little spot here.

[audio interlude]

MR: A nice groove, very nice.

BP: I love playing with that band because you see you have such freedom. There's no drummer behind you, I mean —

MR: How much music does he write out? Quite a bit of it? And you get the solo spot?

BP: No. Well quite a bit for the form, but it doesn't seem like much. Melba Liston is responsible for the arrangements. And I don't know they're really not extensive, not like a big band with an A, B, C and D. There will be a line here, a whole 16 bars or whatever, 32, and then there'll be maybe a middle or a transition. But actually it's built around the solos and stuff. The written music is for interludes or set-ups for the solos.

MR: I was glad to see her name.

BP: Oh, she had a birthday two days ago, Melba Liston. Wonderful woman.

MR: She's on the west coast isn't she?

BP: No, she lives here now.

MR: She lives here now.

BP: Yeah. She's been here for about two or three years. She's been wheelchair bound for a little while, but she and Randy are very close, and he really looks out — oh he's a wonderful human being. When I was going through this dialysis, before I got a kidney

transplant, he was benevolent enough or kind enough to really arrange for me, because dialysis is something you have to do every week no matter whether you're in Europe or not. So dialysis is that method that is used when you have kidney failure, when your kidneys don't function. You go to the hospital for 3-1/2 hours and they put you on a machine that does work that your kidneys would do if they were working. At any rate he arranged for me to have this done three times a week in Europe, well he helped make arrangements. And when we had to travel by bus, well first of all he's six foot six or something, with long legs, well traveling is not a problem, it certainly doesn't seem to be because he comes across the Atlantic like it's the crosstown bus, or the Pacific Ocean. But at any rate my point is instead of looking out for his comfort, he had the back of the bus prepared like a bed for me. And even on this last tour, it might have been around this time we played Seville, Spain, sometimes we had to wake up at six o'clock in the morning or seven and stuff, and you'd have to change planes two or three times. One of those mornings he knocked on my door at seven o'clock and said, "Benny, can I help you with your bags out?" I said, "Man, you're the boss, I'm supposed to be helping you," I said, "You don't know how to be a boss man, you're supposed to be tough." But he's just a wonderful — I can't sing his praises enough. In fact I told you before, I'm doing presentations or programs for the New York organ donor network. I use him as an example of an employer understanding an employee's problems, especially like this because what he empowered me to feel like, although I had this kidney thing I was still a valuable person. And as I listen to this, with Randy, it's a perfect spot for me. Because when I was with Basie's band, well kind of all my life I kind of lived in the shadow of Al Grey. And rightly so. Al Grey is one of the best trombone players ever. I didn't realize how good he was myself until just recently. Because somehow in bands with Basie's band and stuff, you don't think, well I wish I had more solos. When I was with Lionel Hampton's band, we were first with Lionel Hampton's band in the late 40s, Al had just left Jimmy Lunceford's band. I had just left New Orleans. So it was easy to understand. Anyway my solo work has been limited by various factors. One, working with a big band and stuff—

MR: You don't get that many.

BP: I was assured of playing the bridge of "April in Paris" with Basie's band, because sometimes there was a lot of things we had with Judy Garland. It was so funny, I was watching a show the other night, well I was watching this film clip that somebody sent to me, Judy Garland, Mel Torme, and I think it might have been The Sammy Davis Jr. Show, that was done in Brooklyn like 1964 or something. But anyway, they played "April in Paris," and I was getting all set to see myself play my little bridge, Mel Torme sang it. So you know, you're sitting up there, oh, this is NBC, they're finally going to see me, then you go to rehearsal, "Well when we get to that part, Mel, you"— So to be with Randy, you can play until you're blue in the face with Randy. I mean you can play long solos. I run out of breath before we run out of time.

MR: You're making up for — I guess everything comes around. I wanted to fill in a couple of holes in your history here. I know that you have worked with a familiar name, King Kolax?

BP: Yeah. He was with Billy Eckstine's band the same time as all the guys — I think Charlie Parker was there. In 1946 I think he broke off and organized his own band. And when I joined him he had a territory band, well not a territory, it was in Port Arthur, Texas, and there was this guy from my neighborhood going to join, so my mother let me go. And that was my first time, the first band I played with.

MR: You were 16?

BP: Yes.

MR: 16.

BP: Well was I 16 or 17? I was in college. I went to Alabama State Teacher's College when I was 16.

MR: Did you at that point, 16 or 17, envision that you were on the road to becoming a professional musician?

BP: Well I was a professional from 1944, when I first got — to me the difference between a professional and an amateur is the professional gets paid. So the first time I got paid I was professional.

MR: Do you recall what you got paid that first time?

BP: No I don't, but I know my mother was impressed with it. She said, "Well son, you can make this much money in one night? Of course you can be a musician."

MR: That's terrific. How did the gig with Lionel Hampton come about?

BP: I'm glad you asked that because I have to give credit to Betty Carter. Betty Carter was with Lionel Hampton's band. At this time I was playing with another band. I had left King Kolax and joined Ernie Fields' band. He was based out of Tulsa, Oklahoma. So evidently they are close to each other. The night before they played Tulsa, Oklahoma, Lionel Hampton's trombone player left, I never did find out the reason, Chips Outcalt. He was a guy that used to play with Billy Eckstine's band. I did this because I think he played valve trombone. Anyway he left the band in Oklahoma City, so when they got to Tulsa, I don't know if they were looking for a trombone player, but anyway Hamp went to Betty Carter, because at this time she was known as Betty Bebop, so she was his consultant to the guys who were in the modern — and you know Hamp always wanted to be modern. So I understand she gave thumbs up for me. And I didn't find this out until, she never mentioned it to me, I don't know maybe about 20 years ago, when one of my nieces who is an attorney was at a banquet, some big time Washington stuff, and she went to say hello to Betty Carter, and ask if you remember my uncle Benny, and Betty Carter told her this story then. So I was very surprised to hear this, and I was every more surprised because usually when people do something like that they'll say, "Well you know I started your career." She never did that one time. And we were good friends, I mean we didn't keep in touch with each other that much, but we always loved and respected each other.

MR: That band did quite a bit of showmanship?

BP: Oh yeah. I see some of those film clips now. We did some film shorts for Schneider. I remember Schneider productions. But we did all kinds of visual stuff I think when the tempo was up. If you see some of those film clips [claps hands], but I was really glad I went through that school, and Quincy always talks about the same thing. Because it let both of us know that this was show business. You see a lot of guys who become jazz artists who think it's impure to show any kind of emotion, well at one point, not so much now. But you remember when everybody was too cool, so cool. I mean you step on a guy's foot and he'd say ouch next week. That's how cool we all were. I hope I'm not getting too far away from the point. But you know we're all so filled with stories, and one time, I can't really remember it was in Germany or somewhere, Randy, working with

Randy Weston, he usually goes on first and plays a solo for a few minutes while we're still upstairs in the dressing rooms. One of these times I was putting on my costume, because we wear African clothes, and listening to him on the monitor. And man, I know he plays marvelous concerts, solo concerts. He was playing so much piano that I told the guys in the band, "Damn, Randy doesn't need us out her with him, what the hell are we doing out here?" Anyway it dawned on me after a little while, I said, "Randy, I finally figured out what we're doing out here. You just don't want to have to go back to one of these little hotels in France, or whatever, at two o'clock and not have anybody to swap stories with." So I said, "I know that's why you want me here because I'm your age and we can talk about all this stuff." Anyway I'm just kidding, but this is a favorite pastime of musicians.

MR: I love to hear it. Absolutely. How did you end up in Ottawa?

BP: I was with Lionel Hampton's band and I think it was my first time being outside of the United States. At this time I wasn't even 20 or 21. Between racial prejudice and some kind of petty things that went on with this organization, things I thought were petty, I was kind of fed up. When I finally was exposed to another culture in Canada where being black was an asset rather than a liability, I remember the president of the jazz club was a big judge, Judge Enger in Ottawa, and I said wow, this is another level. I remember, you know I think it was when I moved back here I remember seeing my first kind of art film, color in relation to notes, and I remember the soundtrack was played by Oscar Peterson, this was Canada mind you. Anyway, I played there with Lionel Hampton's band and the culture, it was the first time I felt that kind of freedom. So I said this is a good time as ever to come back. So I think I left Lionel Hampton's band. You know I can't really remember, I'm sure I left amicably because I was never one to blow up or anything. Anyway I moved back to this town Hull, Quebec because I think I had met a musician and I was in touch with him, and he invited me back. I think my room rent and board was something like five dollars a week. I could have lived up there the rest of my life on three hundred bucks. But I went back there and it was the first time I had a chance to experience another culture or see that jazz was something that crossed racial lines and social lines, the whole bit.

MR: Was there enough work up there for you to stay?

BP: On five dollars a week—

MR: I know it doesn't take an awful lot.

BP: But fortunately I got a chance to try — yes, because I'd just played there with Lionel Hampton so I moved back and I'm going to stay. In fact there were only two black people in the town, myself and a guy from Nova Scotia, so I was exotic. Man I'd have little old ladies following me down the street asking me if they could touch my hair. So this had never happened, little old ladies were running from me in America. And we had just played this hotel, the Hotel Chaudiere I remember, I think it was in Ottawa. Where I lived was Hull Quebec, it was sort of like just over the bridge, sort of like Brooklyn-Queens from New York. Anyway I think I worked at this hotel and it was odd because since there weren't any other black guys up there, everything I did was exotic. If I coughed they thought I was Billy Eckstine. You know if I walked fast I was Bill Robinson. So I could do no wrong. So I started trying to sing then, and I didn't realize it had been that long since I'd been trying to sing, and then I think I was playing bongo drums, so I was just really stretching out to see, and it all worked fine because I had it made. I was exotic, anything I did was. But in my own mind I saw that being black could be an asset or a liability according to what situation I put myself in, and how I looked at it.

MR: Yeah. Did you notice a similar, more positive atmosphere in Europe when you went there?

BP: Well I'm not a good judge because I went there with Count Basie and the whole world loved Count Basie's band. I always enjoyed myself in Europe, but every time I've gone I've been like a celebrity working with somebody else. I did get a chance to live there in 1980, but then I was playing the show "Ain't Misbehavin'" So I was kind of — my feelings about it would be completely different from a sideman who went over there. I had a big time job and high visibility. So I love Europe. It loves me.

MR: I had another thing to ask you about. For one thing you had said that when you were there you missed the authenticity — was it the culture or the music or both?

BP: Both, both. Since, I've realized that to me there's nowhere like New York — well to me I feel like when you leave New York you're out of town. No matter what it is, Budapest or Birmingham. And I guess that extends to here as well. I have a daughter who lives in Atlanta. And I go to visit her, and everywhere I go I think well could I live here? Would I

be happy living here? I guess if it was near the airport, that's my only thing, but right now New York is it for me man. New York is a whole playground everyday. Everything is here, plus the energy, for me — but I guess it's a culmination of what I felt then. I think I told you last time, in the 70s and 80s, a lot of musicians my age moved to New York successfully: Art Farmer, Johnny Griffin to name two. And I thought about it also. But I kept procrastinating. And the first time I got a chance to really do it was in 1980 when I went with "Ain't Misbehavin'" But before, well I really waited. A lot of guys, well for instance Joe Newman, Buddy Tate, Al Grey, the Basieites who went over and did very well there. When I started thinking about the reality of that, you see, a lot of times those guys were on their own catching trains with bags and all of that stuff, so after a while it's not too glamorous. You know, you're in Switzerland, and there's a flight of stairs big as this is with four escalators and all of that, well I was on that before. But anyway I decided then that that was one of the reasons, the physical one, but next it was just the music hearing — if I woke up in Switzerland and I heard somebody yodeling everyday, it ain't like hearing B.B. King or Aretha Franklin or Miles Davis. Or just to exaggerate, you'd hear Miles Davis perhaps, but indigenous street music. New York is a whole symphony itself man. With all these races, all these languages and stuff, it sounds to me like a big opera. That's I guess — see I must be getting older. But I'm glad I look at it like that. Because I love New York. Some people have a problem with the crazies here. I have nothing. I find them utterly fascinating. And I can deal with it and talk to them, the crazies, and usually you find that all the crazies have an interesting story to tell. It's more entertaining to me than somebody who goes to the post office every day, not to put them down, but I don't know man, New York has such creativity. It's people have such creativity. We have to be pretty creative just to exist here man. Do you realize how many people are living in this little tiny space?

MR: It just floors me that it all works.

BP: Yeah, right. I had a friend come from Europe, he wasn't used to this, so he says every morning he used to go to his window and look out, just look out, from seven to nine, all these people coming out like little ants, but he said they never bumped into each other. And he said from nine-thirty, they all go back in. And he looks out his window again at eleven to one. But I think for me, people have to have more intelligence here than they do

other places. Otherwise it would be utter chaos. The Haitians have to understand the Chinese, because we all pass each other in the street everyday. So I think just instinctively we've developed a pretty sophisticated way of dealing with each other, and respecting each other's races. That's one of the things I am teaching, I'd like to teach in schools with jazz. I'd like to teach that it is part of my culture, but I mean it's the story of my culture. Now sometimes I'd be just as happy to sit down and let you tell me about The Year of the Monkey, or Yom Kippur, or whatever celebration. I think the next thing in education, and a very important thing, is going to be cultures. Because right now we have such a hodgepodge of everybody, and when we start teaching to appreciate each other's culture I think that's one of the ways for us to go into the next century. If we disregard that, well I don't think there's anything that we can disregard. Because we're doing it now, and respecting each other, but this will just heighten that appreciation because as Americans I think we have the advantage of being able to laugh at other things that we didn't understand, for instance other languages. Americans for a long time would go to France and be mad at the people because they couldn't speak English. But I think that's my point. We're beginning to get around this where we have — well I'll tell you a for instance. I don't have a computer yet. I don't have a computer because whenever I had time, I've been writing to people who have computers, now if I had time I felt like I should get to my horn and practice. I'm finally, I'm getting a computer next week. I've already paid for it, only because my older sister told me that my daughter will be able to keep me in touch with my grandchild's movements much easier by e-mail than calling me. So that's been the impetus for me. Now I can use a computer, you know I teach school and stuff, but it was simply like that, that it finally — because I've really had access to computer for 20 years, whatever.

MR: I wanted to follow up on something that you just mentioned, jazz being the story of your culture and America's culture. There's been a lot of press lately about conflict of looking at jazz history from a racial standpoint. And just a couple of weeks ago there was a thing in the *Times* from an author who was I guess complaining that the white musicians that he considered innovators—

BP: Have you heard him play?

MR: I have not heard this man play.

BP: Well. Well he has his opinion. But for me, I wish we'd get over all of that. Acknowledge that everybody had something to do with this. One of the things I think that's never been played enough is Benny Goodman's role in showing a visible democracy. Up until then you'd see pictures of Franklin Delano Roosevelt with Dr. George Washington Carver; Eleanor Roosevelt with Marion Anderson, but they weren't doing anything. Benny Goodman with Lionel Hampton, Teddy Wilson, Gene Krupa, was one of the first visible evidence that we could work together in that kind of respect. And I don't think history books have made enough of that. I think if that were the case then we wouldn't still have these arguments, because we would decided that then, we all made this stuff. Now if you go into the non-racial thing then you're disrespecting my heritage because you see the blues came from people being whipped and beaten and all of that. I know we'd all like to forget about that, but I think it was because of that — I have a contention, no great art is ever created by happy people. It's always adversity that creates art. So when I do my lectures, I start off my lectures with Negro spirituals because they chronicle the experience, which is "Nobody Knows the Trouble I've Seen," and then I tell the people about the voices being cut off. Anyway, it's a deep story behind it, and can't be left out. That's one of the things that I have a problem with now. A lot of jazz education that's being taught, the people, or the judges and so forth, are people — well IAJE for instance was started by a man from Kansas who was a Stan Kenton fan. And that's great. But the emphasis on a lot of the conferences I've been to, starts jazz off there. And so they kind of leave out Count Basie, Fats Waller, Louis Armstrong, Duke Ellington, and so forth. So I kind of have a problem with that. But whenever I have a problem with anything, rather than complain about it, I provide another solution. That's why I am teaching and stuff. And this guy, I don't know whether I should call his name or not but I guess I shouldn't now that I've made my little smart remarks you know. But I don't know, I think I'd like to get past all of this. Because when you walk to the microphone, it don't know whether you're blue or black or green, a man, a woman, a midget or whatever. And that's the common denominator. Writers have their place and so forth, but when it comes to explaining music and so forth, I say well if you know so much about it, take your horn out and let's play.

MR: It almost seems to go hand in hand with — jazz has been elevated to an art form.

BP: That's what it is. And when I speak of culture, what I've done a lot of times is cultural exchange. When I was in California I did a lot of things with African people. It was an exchange. I did jazz, they did African. I've done a couple of cultural exchanges, and that's what I'm speaking of. It's not either/or, it's and. Jazz is a product of all of us, just like the beginning is a product of my people, there's some other parts that are a product of other people. All kinds of people. I don't know why the name Tubby Hayes keeps ringing in my head, but Tubby Hayes was a saxophonist from England, you know there's always the question about whether white guys could play or not and stuff. Also, one of my favorite saxophonists of all time is Stan Getz. But that thing about who can play because of their skin color, I don't know, I can't really deal with that.

MR: Well said. Tell me about your work with Jane Jarvis, who is one of our favorite people.

BP: Oh, that's the sweetheart. That's right, she's been up to your school. I think maybe about five years ago I played the Sarasota Jazz Festival and it just so happened that we came down on the elevator together, and the dining room was a little short walk outside, it was like a motel type thing. And we walked over and she said, "Are you going to eat?" I kid about I don't know which one of us picked the other one up. I had dinner with her, and she was just utterly fascinating. I think she must have been 80 by then. She's 83 now. Yeah she was 80 because I remember for my own recollection, that weekend I met about three people who were over 80, Jay McShann, Jane Jarvis, and Claude Williams. And I always kid them all I said for me it was no problem figuring out what I was going to eat, I just said give me one of them, whatever they ordered, I'll have the same. Because here they are 80 years old and they're still playing jazz festivals. I want some of that. Whatever is going to let me do that, give me some. So we met then, and we decided that we had crossed paths a lot of times, but both of us took corporate gigs. She worked for BMI, no Muzak.

MR: Muzak.

BP: She worked for Muzak, I worked for Merv Griffin. So both of us are kind of, when you work with corporations you don't see anybody except in the corporation you're with. So we kind of passed each other there. Also, she was an organist at Shea Stadium. I'm not particularly a sports fan, enough to go to the games. Many guys did know her from there: Frank Wess used to go in wherever she was playing and just mess with her, and a lot of

guys. So I knew who she was, Bill Berry, she's a very good friend. And incidentally, the three of us are playing together next Wednesday night in Ft. Lauderdale.

MR: With the Statesmen?

BP: Yeah.

MR: All right.

BP: Bill Berry's there also. So it's funny how everything comes full circle. Anyway we ate and we found out we enjoyed each other's company. I found her utterly delightful and the things she likes. So we kind of kept in touch. I've sort of had a crusade really, to get some acknowledgement or recognition for her, so we formed this trio, Jane Jarvis, Earl May and myself. And we played at Zinno's and when I go down to Ft. Lauderdale, I think when my little stage patter, I'll say that when I was asked to join this band, the Statesman, I had no choice. They had two-thirds of my trio already.

MR: So Earl May's on the gig too, right?

BP: Yes, yes, yes.

MR: You'll be one of the younger guys.

BP: I might be.

MR: Could be.

BP: The last time I played with them I was the young guy. No I think there's somebody from Florida who's not familiar to me. He may be younger than I am. If he is I'll kill him.

MR: Not Jerry Jerome, he's older than you.

BP: No this guy's going to take Jerry's place. Jerry I understand — Jerry is not too well. It's odd that you'd mention that, because I have a tape, a jazz profile that Bill Kirchner put together on Johnny Mandel. It was broadcast over National Public Radio. A fine tape. Johnny Mandel and I used to be roommates with Count Basie's band. Anyway, on this tape he mentions Jerry Jerome and Jerry Jerome's affiliation with bebop. Because there were a lot of guys in it. I mean this, see—

MR: I didn't know that.

BP: And since then I've talked with Jimmy Owens and he said the New School has some of Jerry Jerome's arrangements. So I hope to make a copy of this tape and take it to him because I understand he's not too well.

[pause for drink]

MR: Well after Basie, did you find yourself, you'd had your fill of big bands for a while? Although I know you ended up with Thad Jones.

BP: Yes. I was really trying to get a job with Charlie Ventura. Charlie Ventura had a small group and it was a bit different — I think Jackie Cain and Roy Kral, Jackie & Roy were singing with him. He was playing tenor, and Bennie Green was playing trombone. And it really made for a nice ensemble sound. That is one of the jobs that I wanted that I was seeking. I think I wrote Cannonball Adderley and asked him to add a trombone, because I really did want to play with a smaller group for a while. I wasn't too successful. In fact I went to Mingus' house, Thad was trying to get me in Mingus' band. But it was kind of weird because I remember Pepper Adams was there and he was transcribing something from the piano, and I don't remember saying too much to Mingus, and I don't remember him saying too much to me. I think we were sort of checking each other out. I know I was looking at him to see, cause Mingus had a reputation for — well first of all one of the things that didn't sit too well with me was the reputation that he had for knocking out Jimmy Knepper's two front teeth. So maybe I wanted to work with this guy, but I didn't know about wanting to work for him that bad. Anyway there was a job with Illinois Jacquet that I was trying for. No but all of this is the transition from Hamp's band to Basie's band. When I left Basie's band I was still trying to work in a smaller group. That's why I'm so pleased about Randy's thing, because I've always wanted to work with a small group and here I am 587 and I'm getting the chance to do it.

MR: Tell me about, we're hopping around a little bit but as these things occur to me I want to ask before I forget, the thing with the union and the New School.

BP: Oh, let me finish with Jane.

MR: Oh yes, we jumped off there.

BP: After we talked and so forth we decided we'd keep in touch with each other. We didn't decide to form a group right away. I think maybe I went to visit her and I'd take my horn out and I kid about the kind of day, let's see if I can remember, I'll structure a day. Wake up in the morning, eat our oatmeal, take our pills, practice, take our nap, wake up and have lunch, practice, take another nap— but one of the things I like about hanging with her, she is loose like I am. We sleep when we're sleepy and we eat when we're hungry. You know she doesn't have like a eat at eight o'clock in the morning. So I thoroughly

enjoyed her company, and staying at her house. I found out too that she was a composer. I'd never known anything about that. She wrote 31 tunes for a Broadway show. So she was showing me some of the tunes when I was at her home. And I started playing them, and they started sounding pretty good. So I guess maybe the idea was born for a trio in my head at that time. And then when we put it together, Earl May has always been my very favorite bass player. He's thoroughly supportive, but he's thoroughly nuts, and that's my kind of person. He's a very kind man, but he has one of those subtle senses of humor. I'll tell you a for instance. I was doing a school program and I had this participation for kids. So if I want to tell them about Nat King Cole, I start off with something they know. "How many of you know who Natalie Cole is?" Hands would go up. "Well do you know what she does?" Oh yes, she's a singer. They're little kids. So I say, "Do you know who Natalie Cole's father was?" Just leading up to behind me Earl says "Freddie Hubbard." "Do you know who Natalie Cole's father was?" Yes, Freddie Hubbard. But here I am at a school being serious and all that. Because you see after I teach my students, being a good musician is only half of it. Being a nice person is the other half, or maybe 65 percent. Because New York has a bunch of good musicians, but when you get ready to go out on the road and take somebody out there with you, you're responsible for them, and you certainly don't want to hire anybody who's a drag, anybody who's — I think that's how Jane and I recognized each other right away. We saw that we were both no nonsense people, and we are both hard working people. Anyway, to kind of put an end to this story, Jane is very supportive. She's got me believing I can sing, so I'm singing some of the tunes that she's written, also I've written lyrics to my own song, the first time in 68 years I've ever written music and lyrics. And they're in a metaphysical realm, a religious side of mine. In fact, one of my main influences is O.C. Smith. He was singing with the Count Basie band, he is in church now, he's a minister in this Science of Mind. All of these things are kind of tying in because, because of the spiritual level I'm on now, or level of spirituality, Jane is there, Earl is there, we all, it's like birds of a feather. So besides the music part of it, we have a kind of like spiritual side. So it's pretty complete for three people, and we just have the grandest time. Well I'm fortunate enough now to work with people who I enjoy on the stand and off. That's what I was talking about, being a nice person off the stand.

MR: Excellent advice.

BP: Oh yeah. Well that's what comes — especially in New York man. If you don't want to make it there's somebody else who will make it in the next five minutes, and probably — well the fact that they want to make it is if they're easy to get along with, or you just blew that gig. You don't hesitate in New York man, because the supply and demand, there's a much bigger supply than there is the demand.

MR: I was going to ask if the jazz seems to be getting quite a bit of press lately—

BP: Oh yeah.

MR: And as I said, has been elevated to its rightful status — I wonder if it translates into work though.

BP: Not really. I'll tell you a for instance. We were talking about well I'll start this story all over again, about three or four years ago, myself and three other guys who have been active not only for musicians but civil rights, and a little politically active, decided that we could get some of the things done better with a committee, so we organized a Jazz Advisory Committee for Local 802. One of the first things that we saw as a possible goal was union representation for ourselves as members of the jazz faculty of the New School. We started working on this in April of 1996. I remember very well because I got my kidney transplant in January, two months before that. Anyway, last December in 1998, we finally got a contract ratified with the union. And I think this is historic, this thing is getting a lot of press, in fact you want to shoot these things now or afterwards?

MR: Yeah.

BP: Is there any way we can put this on a stand? Anyway I can hold it up. This first is the *Allegro* newspaper. And it's the union newspaper, and it says "New School Jazz Faculty Ratifies a Historic Contract." It is historic because I think it's the first time any arts department has been represented by the union. The clerical aspects of it, and this is I think going to affect teaching maybe across the board. I think at some time it probably will effect you. You're a teacher and so forth. But this is all for a pension fund first of all, and health & welfare. Now that means the employer pays that for us. I'm fortunate enough to be collecting this because I did Broadway shows for many years. And I had no idea about a pension fund. You know I'm a jazz musician, I just happened to get this Broadway show. Pension? I don't need a pension, I'm never going to die, I'm going to

have fun like this all my life. This is from the *New York Times*, we made the *New York Times*. And it says Jimmy Owens, a spearhead for the thing, he's a very well researched guy, and is myself, and these are two of the students at the New School. This guy's from Portugal, and I think she's from North Carolina by — oh no it's the other way around. This guy is from Portugal, she is from California by way of North Carolina. Both of these are excellent students. Now the New School staff has grown very much due to our celebrity. But although we had celebrities of people like Reggie Workman, Cecil McBee, Charlie Persip, oh you can name all of the great jazz musicians, Joe Chambers, are working there. Now we've been used in ads and so forth to attract students, and the student enrollment has doubled like two hundred percent or something. But until we had union contract ratification, we were not seeing that. We'd see all these students come there, and I personally felt kind of used. But fortunately the New School is a progressive thinking institution, and in negotiations, I wasn't on any negotiating committee, but I think what I liked about it was both sides acted admirably. We didn't have any —nobody had to go to the press, and threaten to burn the building down. We were also very fortunate to have a very, I think understanding person in the person of Dr. Barbara Emerson, who is Vice President of Programming. She is also the daughter of Reverend Hosea Williams from the civil rights movement. And she's fairly new in the jazz program this year. When I found out she was there I had a meeting with her in her office and I said, "You're the answer to my prayer." Because I wanted to see things improved, but we are in such an infancy, you know yourself, you work at an institution, the bureaucracy of things that can get in your way when you're trying to make a change especially. So I think we have — I'm very optimistic about how things are moving now. What we are trying to do with this committee is show musicians that instead of complaining, they can actually do something about the situation. And I feel very good that we're kind of achieving that. I feel especially good because I've been able to keep my career going as well as —

MR: Yeah. It can become consuming when you get involved in something.

BP: Well for example Bill Crow, I don't know if you know him he's a bass player.

MR: Yes I do.

BP: He's with the union, he's there almost full time so he doesn't get a chance to do the traveling that I'm doing. But he's nonetheless a fine bass player. And he's doing his part there too. I think he's head of some part of the union that's doing the same thing, trying to enlighten musicians about — I think they're called the Musician's Assistance Program. They had a seminar, and it's a seminar just trying to enlighten musicians to what they can do about their own plights.

MR: You had a couple of more pictures here, and I wonder if we could take a look at them?

BP: Yeah. Well let me get the current stuff out. Recently I went to Japan. That was very interesting because I went by myself, I wasn't with anybody's band, I was just invited as a guest. One of the jobs I worked with was an amateur band, but for the most part I worked six different concerts with six different bands in six different halls, in two days.

MR: In two days.

BP: Two days. It was Kobe Jazz Festival. And it was all done in eight hours those two days, because we did this from 12-4, three concerts a day. Like 12 to 12:40, 2 to 2:40 or something like that. You know by 4 o'clock you're finished. anyway this was very successful for me because I don't get a chance to go out of the country by myself that much, just by myself, just on my own merit. I'm usually with somebody else who has a name. I think there are some places where if I went by myself nobody would show up because you know I'm not really a household name. Anyway this was very interesting in Japan and I enjoyed that. I have a very dear friend, Ken Fujiwara is his name, he used to have Ken Records here, some of Conrad Herwig's albums were recorded by this man, my Japanese friend. He lives there now, and he's the one who brought me over. Next year I hope to release an album through his company in Japan, something that I recorded with Clifford Jordan and Vernel Fournier. I've got some things in the can that I've always tried to do my own thing, not really, of course I tried to get a record deal like anybody else, but the records I've done, I've produced with Merv Griffin money, or I've had to do my stuff myself. But consequently, at this point, I have all the rights. I have the original tapes and stuff, because I did it. So now I'm in the process of releasing some of these things. And I've got some marvelous stuff. I've got a tape that shows some of the finest work of Vernel Fournier, Jack Wilson, he's a pianist in California, Ted Dunbar, Clifford Jordan, all these are on one album, and most of these guys are not here anymore, and if

they are they're not around really playing anymore. So that's my purpose for releasing these things more so than a hit album. I doubt if I'll ever — I've given up on the idea of becoming a popular star. I don't think I ever wanted that man, because I like my private life. And consequently I've done my own booking and so forth because if I want to go and visit my kids and my granddaughter, I don't want anybody telling me but I booked this and you've got to go and do that. So consequently I guess I've got 50 percent of something as opposed to 100 percent of nothing, and that's what a lot of that can be. You know it seems like you're being very successful but you've got people telling you when to breathe. So that doesn't work.

MR: Well it occurs to me that we've been talking for about an hour and I have yet to hear you moan and complain about anything.

BP: Oh that's a luxury I can't afford.

MR: Well you know, not everybody is like that.

BP: Well I think it would help if they were because I think positive things happen for you only if you think positively, and if you make a bad thing, if you turn a bad thing into a good thing. For instance, like with slavery, maybe if we hadn't had any slavery we wouldn't have had a Sarah Vaughan or Billie Holiday and all of that because that's why I think you can't wipe out the racial lines. But my point is I guess in my life I've taken things — for instance, when I took a job with Merv Griffin, many guys I'm sure said, "Benny Powell is selling out," or whatever. I've had jobs, but I would work with Merv Griffin and get finished with that and go out and play with Thad Jones in the evening. So I guess I, and many people remarked that I came through this kidney dialysis and all of that — in fact Clark Terry calls me King. Now can you imagine that? I just got a message from him, he called and played Happy New Years, but man not in my wildest dreams — Max Roach had some kind of name for me. Now these guys, I came up like a kid, idolizing these guys. Now that's really because I had a life threatening thing, that has nothing to do with music at all. But that's what I'm saying. If I had looked at oh woe is me, in fact when it first happened to me I talked to one of my sisters I think when it first happened to me, when I was first inconvenienced by it. My sister said, "I don't know why it happened to you brother," but she says, "if you think about what you have as opposed to what you've lost, and work with that, I'm sure everything will be fine." And

at that point I realized how lucky I had been and how lucky I still was. I had something to work with. And I think that if you keep your mind busy, and music is humbling itself, I'm still trying to learn how to play trombone. I have no time to think about I'm sick. I would never have been able to play that way. So have we used up all your tape?

MR: How we doing there, Tim? The pictures.

BP: Oh yeah, as I was digging out, I don't know I was going through looking for other things and I happened to find, I've got a whole archive in my house man, because I'm one of those people who saved everything. I've got newspaper clippings from Count Basie when I was with his band in the 50s in Europe. In fact I've got some pay receipts from Lionel Hampton from 1948, just because I kept all these things. Anyway, these are the members of Count Basie's band. These are alumni. Because I think in this picture there's Joe Newman, Frank Wess, me with hair, I'm sorry Joe Newman, Frank Foster, Benny Powell, Frank Wess. Behind us is Jimmy Owens because this was done at his home. The other guys are a film crew from Holland who came over to do a piece on Count Basie's band. This is, I've been very fortunate to play with some of the greats. This is one of the greats. This is Mr. Eddie Durham, who played trombone as well. But actually I guess his claim to fame, many people have danced to his compositions and not realized it. "In the Mood" is one of the most known pieces of all time in America. This is the guy who wrote it and sold it to Glenn Miller. He used to be a staff arranger. He was a very fascinating man. A lot of times when I do these educational programs, I really like to do things like this and show, because a lot of times people have ideas that jazz is a starvation thing, and so forth, you show some of the pictures of Duke Ellington's band, Benny Carter's band in 1934, they're traveling in the south yet these guys have got pearl gray suits on with spotless white shoes. So that's a long way from the pictures that's portrayed of black people in those days. This was at a party given by BMI the publishers. And they're significant because of all — well they're significant to me, I am in the company of all my people that I've idolized for years: Roy Eldridge, Sy Oliver, Lionel Hampton, Milt Hinton, George Simon, Gary Burton and Helen — I can't remember her name but she was president of BMI. There I am, and Doc Cheatham, I don't remember this lady, but this is Max Roach and Oliver Jackson. So to me, just to be in the same room, and much less on a picture, is something that I'll always cherish. Lionel Hampton was my first big

band leader friend. This was taken on a tour with Randy Weston, when Dizzy Gillespie was sick. We were in Europe at the time. This is Randy of course, this is Talib Kibwe, this is Stafford James and me, and Eric Assasnte, that's his name, Eric Ajie is the comic. Eric Assante. When Dizzy was sick we took this picture, we love you Dizzy, to send to him. Again, this is taken at the same party and the same people. I don't know who this gentleman is at the top here. Do you recognize him?

MR: No.

BP: And the last is Lionel Hampton, Gary Burton and myself, and I don't know who the bass player was. But every so often when I'm going through files and stuff, I'll run across pictures like this, and to me, right now, I'm sort of objective about it. It's like it happened to somebody else. And I still feel like a little kid when I'm around — just recently I was at Lincoln Center two nights ago, and to pay tribute to Duke Ellington, and well even around Max and Randy, I still feel like the little kid who's wow, these are my idols. I still really do feel like it. And I'll tell you even more so. I was at a tribute to Clark Terry a little while ago, and I had the pleasure of sitting next to Jonah Jones and talking to him, and it was utterly fascinating. He was able to talk about Roy Eldridge when he was a little kid, Quentin Jackson, some obscure musicians to the general public, but nevertheless friends of mine, and to see him light up when he talked about all of these things was just a delight.

MR: Well I can relate to that because that's how I feel being around guys like you.

BP: Oh thank you. Well when we're sitting around telling stories, well I think it's a good feeling for all of us. Because I think those of us who really love jazz have a humility about it. We realize that none of it is a big deal, the big deal is just being a nice human being or trying to be the same kind of human being Duke Ellington, Ella Fitzgerald, Count Basie, Sarah Vaughan. If you can live up to their humanity, hopefully you'll make some good music.

MR: Well speaking of good music, I just wanted to ask you if you remember the specifics of this particular recording session.

[audio interlude "April in Paris"]

BP: My first impression is how blessed I am to have been a part of that because as I hear it I think about Freddie Green, I think about Marshall Royal, that was just the two things that

jumped out at me right away, since Marshall Royal played lead alto and it was so solid, then you could hear Freddie Green in the back. I don't really remember as much from this date as I do from the one we did with Duke Ellington.

MR: Oh, both bands?

BP: Yes. It was called Battle Royal. I think I was like a kid in a candy store because I think where I was seated, I was sort of like I was in eyeshot of both Basie and Duke Ellington, and I kept pinching myself, I said you're not here, you're going to wake up any minute. And these guys were such statesmen themselves, because someone remarked the other night at Lincoln Center on the Duke Ellington thing, about that same date. I think it ended up with Basie playing solo on "Take the A Train," and Duke playing a solo on "One O'Clock Jump." But those guys were such statesmen, they'd say, "Well Mr. Basie, this number just demands your presence." "But no, Maestro, I wouldn't dare." Oh man those guys were cool. Oh man. And I was a little kid, you know, and I'm looking at these guys. And I don't believe it. But also I remember one of the biggest sensual thrills I've ever gotten, on the end there's both of these bands playing these huge chords, I think that arrangement was by Jimmy Jones who used to be accompanist for Sarah Vaughan. I think he had a hand in that. But man at the end there's some power chords in Sonny Payne's solo. The drum is playing through all of that. Oh man, if you were in the room, sometimes try it yourself. Go to somewhere in a pretty enclosed room, and turn up the sound. Oh man. I mean it will just do all sorts of thing to your cells. It will rearrange your cells. But I think I remember that more than.

MR: Did you guys ever have a sense of when one particular song was going to hit for the band?

BP: No. Well I always say that. Nobody knows when anything is going to be a hit, otherwise we'd all have hits.

MR: That's true.

BP: And Basie himself, I hope I've learned something from him so far as how to take a natural thing and make it saleable. Because it was so natural for him to say one more time on the end, but that sold it as much as the music did. Because at the end he says "one more time" and we play it all over again. Now this, I remember, we did a movie with Jerry Lewis, "Cinderfella." And this little creative bit that Basie did on it made this

usable to many things. I think I've done some things with Sammy Davis Jr. and so forth. And it became almost like a Coca Cola commercial — one more time. But Basie was very slick that way. And I guess I did learn something from him because I'm still around and I'm still doing it. But he was so natural man. What he did was so simple, everyone would think why didn't I think of that, it was right in front of me? And so was Duke. All those guys were special breeds of people. A special breed I should say.

MR: Well, fascinating. I really appreciate your time again. And I wish you the best in your travels, and all your projects, and your work with Jane.

BP: One time, let me put in my bid for us, if possible, why don't you have a residency with Jane and I and Earl?

MR: That would be a good combination.

BP: In fact if we can talk about it afterwards, maybe I can help you find some money for it.

MR: Yeah?

BP: Yeah. You're in New York State?

MR: Yeah. We're outside Utica.

BP: Well we have the National Endowment and the New York State Council on the Arts.

MR: Well there you go, I'd love to.

BP: But because just to do this same thing, I'd like to say I'm glad, thank you first of all, for allowing me to do this, to document it. Because one of the good things is we have this technology now, you see before you either had to write it down or read a book or something, you can see it coming from the horse's mouth. And I'm sure, I'd really like to come up to your place and look at all the tapes you've done of the other guys. I know Snooky Young, and Joe Williams was 80 years old, did you know?

MR: Yeah. I guess he had a big party at Liberace's estate.

BP: Yeah. "From the home of Liberace," oh, that would be like Joe. I saw him at the White House, they did a thing at Christmas in Washington, D.C, no, no it was a thing at the Kennedy Center where they honored Bill Cobs, but Joe was in the audience.

MR: By the way, have you ever read his biography?

BP: Joe's?

MR: By Leslie Gourse?

BP: Yes.

MR: Okay. He mentions some nice things about you too.

BP: Oh yeah. It's funny because Leslie Gourse made him come out like Erroll Flynn. He was Joe Williams the lover I think. No it was good through because Joe is a class act. In fact one of my greatest gigs was with him about two or three years ago. He was working at the Skyland Room, what is it, NBC—

MR: The Rainbow Room.

BP: The Rainbow Room, yes. He had four weeks there. And each week he would invite another guest musician and I was a guest for one week, and had such a great time. Because to me first of all he's the consummate professional. So you know being that he certainly made me comfortable and put me in spotlights where I'd look good. So he's a dynamite person.

MR: Great. Well thanks for your time.

BP: My pleasure.

MR: Stay healthy.

BP: I intend to, thank you, and the same to you.

MR: Okay.